

# THE AUXILIARY VERB

## Recognize an auxiliary verb when you find one.

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Each sentence must have a **verb**. To describe actionable activities, writers use action verbs. To describe conditions, writers choose linking verbs. Sometimes an action or condition occurs only once-bang!-and it is over.

Nate **stubbed** his toe.

He **is** miserable with pain.

Other times, the activity or condition continues over a long period of time, happens predictably, or occurs in relation to other events. In these cases, a single-word verb such as **stubbed** or **is** cannot accurately describe what happened, so writers use multipart verb phrases to convey what they mean. Up to four words can make up a verb phrase.

A main or base verb indicates the type of action or condition, and auxiliary or helping verbs convey the other nuances that writers want to express.

Read these three examples:

-Mary **smacked** her lips as raspberry jelly **dripped** from the donut onto her white shirt.

-Mary **is** always **dripping** something.

-Since Mary is such a klutz, she **should have been eating** a cake doughnut, which **would not have stained** her shirt.

In the first sentence, **smacked** and **dripped**, single-word verbs, describe the quick actions of both Mary and the raspberry jelly.

Since Mary has a pattern of messiness, **is dripping** communicates the frequency of her clumsiness. The auxiliary verbs that comprise **should have been eating** and **would have stained** express not only time relationships but also criticism of Mary's actions.

Below are the auxiliary verbs. You can conjugate **be**, **do**, and **have**; the modal auxiliaries, however, never change form.

| BE    | DO   | HAVE   |
|-------|------|--------|
| am    | does | has    |
| is    | do   | have   |
| are   | did  | had    |
| was   |      | having |
| were  |      |        |
| being |      |        |
| been  |      |        |

| MODAL AUXILIARIES (NEVER CHANGE FORM)                              |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------|
| can, could, may, might, must, ought to, shall, should, will, would |

## Understand the dual nature of **be**, **do**, and **have**.

**Be**, **do**, and **have** are both stand-alone verbs *and* auxiliary verbs. When these verbs are auxiliary, you will find them teamed with other words to complete the **verb phrase**.

Compare these sentences:

Freddy **is** envious of Beatrice's steaming bowl of squid eyeball stew.

**Is** = **linking verb**.

Freddy **is studying** Beatrice's steaming bowl of squid eyeball stew with envy in his eyes.

*Is* = auxiliary verb; *studying* = present **participle** completing the verb phrase.

We **did** our homework for Professor Long.

*Did* = **action verb**.

We are not slackers! We **did prepare** our homework for Professor Long.

*Did* = auxiliary verb; *prepare* = main verb completing the verb phrase.

Selena **has** twelve orange goldfish in her aquarium.

*Has* = action verb.

Selena **has bought** a catfish to help keep the tank clean.

*Has* = auxiliary verb; *bought* = past participle completing the verb phrase.

## Form progressive tenses with the auxiliary verb *be*.

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All progressive tenses use a form of *be*.

| FORMS OF BE                         |
|-------------------------------------|
| am, is, are, was, were, being, been |

### PRESENT PROGRESSIVE

Present progressive follows this pattern:

**AM, IS, OR ARE** + **PRESENT PARTICIPLE**

Use the present progressive tense to convey an action or condition happening **right now** or frequently.

I **am baking** chocolate-broccoli muffins today.

*Am* = auxiliary verb; *baking* = present **participle** completing the **verb phrase**.

Alex **is sitting** at the kitchen table, anticipating his first bite.

**Is** = auxiliary verb; **sitting** = present participle completing the verb phrase.

Alex must wait a while longer because the muffins **are cooling** by the window.

**Are** = auxiliary verb; **cooling** = present participle completing the verb phrase.

Impatient Alex **is** always **waiting** to taste whatever I cook.

**Is** = auxiliary verb; **waiting** = present participle completing the verb phrase.

## PAST PROGRESSIVE

Past progressive follows this pattern:

**WAS OR WERE** + **PRESENT PARTICIPLE**

Use the past progressive tense to show either 1) an action or condition that continued in the past or 2) an action or condition interrupted by another.

Naomi **was hoping** for an A in her organic chemistry class.

**Was** = auxiliary verb; **hoping** = present **participle** completing the **verb phrase**.

Unfortunately, Naomi's lab reports **were missing** the nutritional data on chocolate-broccoli muffins.

**Were** = auxiliary verb; **missing** = present participle completing the verb phrase.

While Naomi **was obsessing** about her grade, Jason shared the data that she needed.

**Was** = auxiliary verb; **obsessing** = present participle completing the verb phrase.

## FUTURE PROGRESSIVE

Future progressive follows this pattern:

**WILL** + **BE** + **PRESENT PARTICIPLE**

Use the future progressive tense to indicate an action that will continue in the future.

I **will be growing** broccoli in the backyard this spring.

**Will, be** = auxiliary verbs; **growing** = present **participle** completing the **verb phrase**.

Soon, Alex **will be eating** organic chocolate-broccoli muffins!

**Will, be** = auxiliary verbs; **eating** = present participle completing the verb phrase.

## Form passive voice with the auxiliary verb *be*.

You can make any **transitive verb**—that is, an **action verb** that can take a **direct object**—passive with the auxiliary verb **be**.

| FORMS OF BE                         |
|-------------------------------------|
| am, is, are, was, were, being, been |

Active voice follows this pattern:

**SUBJECT** + **VERB** + **DIRECT OBJECT**

Here are examples:

We **licked** our lips.

Frank **devoured** a bacon double cheeseburger.

Everyone **envied** his enjoyment.

Passive voice makes these changes:

**DIRECT OBJECT AS THE SUBJECT** + **FORM OF BE** + **PAST PARTICIPLE** + **BY**  
+ **SUBJECT AS THE OBJECT OF THE PREPOSITION**

Now read these revisions:

Our lips **were licked** by us.

The double bacon cheeseburger **was being devoured** by Frank.

His enjoyment **was envied** by everyone.

Notice how wordy and clunky passive voice is! Now you know why English teachers tell you to avoid it!

## Form perfect tenses with the auxiliary verb *have*.

All perfect tenses use a form of *have*.

| FORMS OF HAVE          |
|------------------------|
| has, have, had, having |

### PRESENT PERFECT

Present perfect follows this pattern:

**HAS OR HAVE** + **PAST PARTICIPLE**

Use the present perfect tense to convey an action or condition that began in the past but continues (or is finished) in the present.

Marge **has bought** earplugs to drown out her husband's snoring.

**Has** = auxiliary verb; **bought** = past **participle** completing the **verb phrase**.

The earplugs **have saved** Marge's marriage to George.

**Have** = auxiliary verb; **saved** = past participle completing the verb phrase.

## PAST PERFECT

Past perfect follows this pattern:

**HAD** + **PAST PARTICIPLE**

Use the past perfect tense to show that one action in the past occurred before another.

Because Marge **had purchased** the earplugs, she no longer fantasized about smothering George with a pillow.

**Had** = auxiliary verb; **purchased** = past **participle** completing the **verb phrase**.

## FUTURE PERFECT

Future perfect follows this pattern:

**WILL** + **HAVE** + **PAST PARTICIPLE**

Use the future perfect tense to indicate that an action will be finished in the future.

This Sunday, Marge **will have gotten** an entire week of uninterrupted sleep.

**Will, have** = auxiliary verbs; **gotten** = past **participle** completing the **verb phrase**.

## Form emphatic tenses with the auxiliary verb **do**.

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When you use a form of **do** as an auxiliary verb, you form the emphatic tense. This tense is useful for asking questions or emphasizing an action.

| FORMS OF DO          |
|----------------------|
| does, do, did, doing |

These are the patterns:

**FORM OF DO** + **MAIN VERB**

**FORM OF DO** + **SUBJECT** + **MAIN VERB** ... ?

Read these samples:

I **did** not **eat** your leftover pizza!

**Did** = auxiliary verb; **eat** = main verb completing the **verb phrase**.

**Do** you always **accuse** the first person you see?

**Do** = auxiliary verb; **accuse** = main verb completing the verb phrase.

**Doesn't** the evidence **point** to Samuel, who still has a bit of black olive stuck to his front tooth?

**Does** = auxiliary verb; **point** = main verb completing the verb phrase.

## Understand the job of modal auxiliary verbs.

Modal auxiliary verbs never change form. You cannot add an **ed**, **ing**, or **s** ending to these words. They have only *one* form.

| MODAL AUXILIARIES (NEVER CHANGE FORM)                              |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------|
| can, could, may, might, must, ought to, shall, should, will, would |

You can use modal auxiliary verbs in these patterns:



**MODAL** + **MAIN VERB**

**MODAL** + **BE** + **PRESENT PARTICIPLE**

**MODAL** + **HAVE** + **PAST PARTICIPLE**

With modal auxiliaries, you can indicate *necessity* or *obligation*:

To lose her orange glow, Yvonne **should eat** fewer carrots.

John **must remember** his wife's birthday this year.

If Cecilia wants a nice lawn, she **ought to be raking** the leaves.

Or you can show *possibility*:

Fred **might share** his calculus homework if you offer him a slice of pizza.

Ann **could have run** the half marathon if she had started to train four months ago.

Modal auxiliaries also show *willingness* or *ability*:

Nicole **will babysit** your pet iguana for a reasonable fee.

Jason **can pass** chemistry this semester if he stops spending his study time at the arcade.

